Form No. 68.

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From St. Petersburg,

February 13, 1902.

Received 7.50 P. M.

Secretary of State,

Washington.

February 13, 5 P. M.

At a personal interview on Wednesday Russian Minister for Foreign Affairs expressed to me, with much earnestness, the surprise and regret of the Emperor of Russia at the step taken by the United States in communicating the recent note relating to the Russian-Chinese Bank, by which the Emperor, as well as the Minister for Foreign Affairs, conceives that a lack of confidence in Russian integrity has been shown which ought not to have been expected from the United States Government, and which appears to them contradictory to the cordial relations existing between the two countries.

I assured Minister for Foreign Affairs that there was not, and there could not have been, any intention to offend the feelings either of the Emperor or himself, but that the inquiry was made on the part of the United States in the same friendly spirit which invariably animates the intercourse between the

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Government of the United States and the Russian Government. I added that the United States Government feels especially solicitous in regard to the policy of the open door in China, which it strenuously advocates in the interest of American commerce, and that it felt concerned at the report received from China that the concessions about to be made to the Russian-Chinese bank were exclusive in character. Hence the United States Government addressed itself to Russia to ascertain whether or not that report were correct. I earnestly requested him to take this view of the incident. He replied, however, that he himself had labored ever since he had been in office to maintain the best relations with the United States; that he is conscious of having done no wrong, and that if the United States had sent him a verbal inquiry as to the facts of the proposed concessions he would freely have given the details and would even have shown the contracts, but he declared with much feeling that he could not escape a sentiment of discourtesy toward Russia in the procedure of the United States when they addressed a formal note to China and Russia simultaneously, making inquiry as to negotiations carried on by Russia as an independent power with China, another independent State, and he thereupon reiter-

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ated his declaration that no independent nation can submit its action, under such circumstances, to the approval of others.

No part of this conversation betrayed anger or hostility on the part of Minister for Foreign Affairs, nor was there any trace of violent language. On the contrary, it expressed throughout disappointment that the recent note did not accord with the sentiments of mutual friendship which Russia expected from former relations, and from recent conversations of President Roosevelt with Russian Ambassador. Minister for Foreign Affairs expressed much apprehension as to the effect produced upon the Oriental mind by a note addressed to China which might give the impression that two of the great Powers were at variance in regard to Chinese affairs.

I repeated my statement to the Minister for Foreign Affairs that I am sure he has misunderstood the sentiments of the United States Government, and promised him to report my conversation to you. I do not think the incident is likely to interrupt the good relations existing between the countries, though I believe it threatens to reduce, in some degree, the cordiality heretofore attained. Minister for Foreign Affairs would be gratified by an expression on the part of the United States Government

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of its acceptance of Russia's statement that it intends to return Manchuria to China, and that it does not intend to depart from its policy heretofore announced.

There is great sensitiveness here in regard to newapaper discussion of Russia's purposes in China, and the hope has been intimated to me that it might not be encouraged.

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